

Sonnets of dark-held love

A sequence of poems
after the [*Sonetos del amor oscuro*](#)
by **Federico García Lorca**

As translated by **Rik Roots**

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Dedicated to anyone who stands up and says
to the faces and fists of Fascism ...

No!

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A howl for garland roses

(After Federico García Lorca's
[*Soneto de la guirnalda de rosas*](#))

Know this: I'm dying! Now! A pretty crown!
You weave it quick for me! And groan – no! Sing!
For soon fell clouds shall knot tight in my throat
again and beyond count, this new year light.

An uncaught space, your love for me and mine
for you – a star's shimmer, a leaf's quick twitch;
amid the anemone thickets summon up
a long, dark moan: a year's own length – entire!

A new landscape freshly drawn from my wound –
enjoy the snapped reeds, the delicate streams.
Come sip honey and blood set on the thigh.

But soon! Make quick that link to reunite
this love's poor broken mouth, its gnawed-on soul,
else time stalks us for destruction: seared wreath!

A growl for sweet complaint

*(After Federico García Lorca's
[Soneto de la dulce queja](#))*

I have a fear: a loss of wonder glimpsed –
that stare, your marbled eyes, and that light tick
your breath at night on my cheek – touch and touch
a single rose brushed in the breeze of sleep.

I hold a sorrow: stuck upon this shore
a twist of trunk, my branches polled – yet most
I have no bloom, no bark or heart or soil
to feed the grubs that feed the pain I shine.

If you alone remain my hidden jewel,
if you're my torture cross, my sweet-sprung hurt –
if I am but a dog at your command,

never let me lose this thing that I've gained
and decorate your river's deepest flow
with a sheen of leaves dropped in my lost fall.

On the wounds of love

(After Federico García Lorca's
[*Llagas de amor*](#))

This searchlight beam, this fire that sears and eats.
This gray haze landscape pressing on my skin.
This stretch of pain to seek that one idea.
This moment's heartbreak: sky and world and time.

This pulse of blood, its spots to decorate
a still and strumless lyre, a slick of flame.
This heft of ocean's wave to hold me down.
This scorpion hid in my ribs: and claws, and sting.

They are a garland love, a bed for wounds
in which I lie dreamless, I dream you here
against my flesh, this chest: heavy and ruined.

And though I seek the peaks of reasoned faith,
your heart presents to me a valley strewn
with hemlock feathers: such a bitter science.

To his love the poet asks: write to me

(After Federico García Lorca's
[*El poeta pide a su amor que le escriba*](#))

My bowel-nested love, my death in life,
a long-drawn time I wait for your new words
and think, beside the bloom now past its peak,
if life excludes the me – you, I want to lose.

The air does not exclude. The lifeless stone
it has no track of shade, no will to hide.
The pulse that moves all hearts, it does not seek
the frozen honey spills the moon pours forth.

And yet you, I have suffered: ripped my veins,
a tiger and dove together, your waist
held for a sharp-edged fight of bites and lilies.

So come, now: make my madness full with words
or let me live each thought in my serene
and shuttered universe; my bones, my night.

The poet says to the truth

(After Federico García Lorca's
[*El poeta dice la verdad*](#))

I want to weep my heart-wrecks: I say this
so you shall come to love and weep for me
one night where nightingales call to the air,
and you and dagger blade and touch and kiss.

I want to kill the only witness, see,
who saw the murder, saw my flowers die
and then I can convert my tears, my sweat
to an everlasting heap of hard wheat.

I hope the loose-spoiled thread of I love you,
of you love me – it never ends: it burns
along with that old moon, the guttered sun.

This thing that you won't give, that I don't seek
from you will be for death, that death which leaves
no shadow marks across the trembling flesh.

The poet speaks on the phone to love

(After Federico García Lorca's
[*El poeta habla por teléfono con el amor*](#))

Your voice, it watered dunes within my chest,
me listening in that sweet wooden stall.
And south beyond my feet there was a spring
and north above my brow a flower fern.

A stretch of slatted light embossed in pine
to sing beyond a dawn, beyond a seed
and my tears became flames for the first time –
a spray of hopeful wreaths to crown the roof.

A sweet yet distant voice for me poured out.
A sweet yet distant voice for me to prize.
So distant, sweet that voice: so dead and still –

a distant voice so like a wounded doe.
And sweet and yet so like a snowfall sob.
So distant, sweet, it marrows into me!

The poet asks his love about the «Enchanted City» of Cuenca

*(After Federico García Lorca's
[El poeta pregunta a su amor por la «Ciudad Encantada» de Cuenca](#))*

You liked the city that by drop on drop
the water carved amid the round of pines?
You saw, did you, the dreams and faces, roads
and walls, those walls of pain the air there whips?

And you saw the blue crack, the broken moon
the Júcar soaks in crystals and their trills?
Your fingers, did their tips then kiss the thorns
that weave in love to crown the distant stone?

Did you remember me as you then climbed
towards those silent jags of rock and snakes,
a prisoner of crickets and soft shades?

Did you not spot beyond the clean, clear air
a dahlia of heartbreaks stitched with joy
that my hot heart commanded up to you?

With Gongorinesque verve a poet sends a dove to his love

*(After Federico García Lorca's
[Soneto gongorino en que el poeta manda a su amor una paloma](#))*

This young Turian dove I send to you,
with sweet bright eyes and plumes so pale and full,
over the noble laurel pours and adds
a slow and loving flame to where I stay.

Its candid virtue, its throat of soft down,
presents a swirl of caught and heated foams
with a trembled frost, pearl and shades of mist –
it seeks to mark an absent mouth: your mouth.

Now pass your hands across its full white space
and you will see flurries of song-spun snow –
it settles on your elegance in flakes.

And thus my heart now caught by night and day
and jailed within these walls of dark-held love
must weep its harsh distress, not seeing you.

Secret voice of dark-held love, you!

(After Federico García Lorca's
[*¡Ay voz secreta del amor oscuro!*](#))

You, there! Secret voice of dark-held love!
Yes you, bleating without wool! You wound!
You gall needle, sunk camellia!
You sea-less current, wall-stripped city!

Unbound night with your certain profile;
God's Own mountain erect with anguish!
You! Dog in my heart, molested voice;
unconfined silence, swollen lily!

Run fast from me, you scald of iced voice;
don't you lose me in brackens and briars
where fruitless they groan – that sky, that flesh.

Let me leave this solid head of bone,
give me a mercy, help break my grief!
For I am love; for I am all life!

Love lies suspended in the poet's chest

(After Federico García Lorca's
[*El amor duerme en el pecho del poeta*](#))

Never will you know how hard I love you;
you sleep in me, a rest of chrysalis.
I'm crying here, now; I hide you, hunted
by a voice that penetrates even steel.

The lore that stirs both flesh and star alike,
it punctures, seeps into my chest in aches –
a stew of mulm words have bitten and chewed
the hard angle wings of your stringent soul.

People cluster in lush gardens: they jump;
they wait to see your shape, my agony;
they ride horses with manes of light and green.

So you must maintain your slumber, my life.
Hear my blood as it breaks in violins!
Can you see them? Still they are stalking us!

A night of sleepless love

(After Federico García Lorca's
[*Noche del amor insomne*](#))

That night and us aloft with the full moon:
it brought me to tears; to you it raised laughs.
Your scorn seemed Godlike, while my grievances
no more than small splinters and doves in chains.

That night and us beneath. Crystal sorrow
brought you to tears for such deep distances.
My anguish formed a harsh cluster of pains
around your weak and sand embedded heart.

The dawn drew us together to the bed,
our mouths set as one to the frozen stream
of a wound without end that pours, that spills.

And the sun broke the shuttered balcony
and the living coral spread wide its fan
around my cold and shroud embedded heart.